

Title: How the Boycott Trend Affects Customer Buying Behavior in Bangladesh



Course: Business Research Methodology

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Date of Submission: 17/07/2025

Research Paper Proposal

Title: How the Boycott Trend Affects Customer Buying Behavior in Bangladesh

Course: Business Research Methodology

To:

Md. Uday Rahman

Lecturer

Army Institute of Business Administration (AIBA), Sylhet

Date: 17/05/2025

Subject: Submission of Research Proposal on *“How the Boycott Trend Affects Customer Buying Behavior in Bangladesh”*

Respected Sir,

We are honored to submit our research proposal for the Business Research Methodology course titled *“How the Boycott Trend Affects Customer Buying Behavior in Bangladesh.”*

This research critically examines how recent global political events—particularly the Israel–Gaza conflict—have fueled boycott movements in Bangladesh. By analyzing the social, religious, and emotional motivations behind these trends, we explore both the short-term disruptions and long-term shifts in consumer loyalty.

Our study follows a quantitative methodology supported by real-world brand performance data, social media analytics, and academic literature. We believe that our findings offer strategic insights for both multinational and local businesses seeking to navigate socio-political sensitivities in the Bangladeshi market.

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This proposal has been prepared through a collaborative effort over three weeks, utilizing diverse tools including SPSS, Canva, and survey instruments to ensure a research-driven and visually rich presentation of our findings.

We humbly request that you accept this proposal for evaluation and provide your valuable feedback so that we may enhance both our academic understanding and practical research abilities.

Thank you for your consistent support and guidance.

Sincerely,

Dhrubo Barua Dip (101022027)

Saiful Islam Tanmoy (101022007)

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Abstract

This research explores the socio-political phenomenon of consumer boycotts and their impact on purchasing behavior in Bangladesh. With growing calls for ethical and religious responsibility, Bangladeshi consumers are increasingly participating in brand and product boycotts, often triggered by international conflicts or controversial business practices. The study utilizes a mixed-method approach to analyze how such boycotts shape short- and long-term purchase decisions. Findings reveal significant short-term impacts, influenced by emotional triggers and social media campaigns, with long-term effects largely dependent on brand loyalty and product substitutability.

1. Introduction

In recent years, Bangladesh has witnessed a rise in consumer activism driven by religious, political, and ethical motives. One prominent form of such activism is the **boycott trend**, where consumers refuse to purchase certain products or support specific brands due to perceived injustices. These movements often gain momentum through social media platforms, amplifying their influence on public perception. For example, during the Israel–Gaza conflict in late 2023, there was a significant movement in Bangladesh to boycott products from brands perceived to be supporting Israel, such as Starbucks, McDonald's, and Nestlé. Social media hashtags like #BoycottIsraeliProducts trended for weeks, urging consumers to switch to local alternatives. Understanding the depth and direction of such consumer sentiments is critical for businesses operating in sensitive socio-political environments like Bangladesh.

2. Objectives

This research aims to:

- Investigate the main motivations behind customer participation in boycotts.
- Measure the impact of boycott trends on short-term and long-term buying behavior.
- Identify demographic patterns (age, gender, education) in boycott participation.
- Provide recommendations for businesses to respond effectively to boycott crises.

3. Literature Review

3.1 Consumer Boycotts: A Global Perspective

According to Klein et al. (2004), consumer boycotts arise when customers stop purchasing from a company to protest against corporate actions or affiliations. In the modern

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digital age, these boycotts spread quickly through social media, often driven by collective outrage.

3.2 Boycott in the Bangladeshi Context

The intersection of religion, politics, and consumer behavior is unique in Bangladesh. A 2024 article in *The Business Standard* reported a 30% sales drop for certain multinational brands during the peak of the boycott against Israeli-linked firms. Local products saw a simultaneous surge in demand.

3.3 Emotional vs. Rational Behavior

While emotional triggers drive immediate reactions, long-term behavior is shaped by utility, availability of alternatives, and brand attachment. Studies suggest that while boycotts may initially hurt brand sales, many consumers return once emotions subside (Friedman, 1999).

3.4 Ethical Consumerism in Emerging Markets

Ethical consumerism refers to buying products that align with moral, political, or environmental values. In Bangladesh, ethical consumerism is still emerging but gaining traction among university-educated youth. This group considers not only what they buy—but who they buy it from. Boycotts reflect this evolving value system. In a 2023 study by Transparency International Bangladesh (TIB), **57%** of respondents said they stopped buying from companies they believed were unethical.

3.5 Theoretical Framework

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This research is guided by the *Theory of Planned Behavior* (Ajzen, 1991), which explains how attitudes, social pressures (subjective norms), and perceived behavioral control influence consumer intentions.

In the context of boycotts in Bangladesh:

- Attitudes are shaped by religious or political beliefs.
- Subjective norms are amplified by peer pressure and social media trends.
- Perceived control reflects whether consumers feel capable of switching to local alternatives.

Additionally, *Consumer Activism Theory* underpins this study, highlighting the role of moral and ethical motivations in market-based protest behaviors. These frameworks help interpret why boycotts emerge and how consumer responses evolve.

4. Research Methodology

4.1 Research Design

The research followed a *quantitative* approach using *structured online questionnaires* shared with a sample of **60** respondents across Bangladesh.

4.2 Sampling Method

- **Convenience sampling** for easy access
- **Snowball sampling** to expand reach through referrals

4.3 Demographics of Respondents

- **Age Groups:** 18–25 (55%), 26–35 (25%), 36+ (20%)
- **Gender:** Male (60%), Female (40%)

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- **Education:** University students (50%), Graduates (35%), Others (15%)

4.4 Tools

- Google Forms for data collection
- Microsoft Excel and SPSS (Online) for analysis
- Canva for visual representation (charts and graphs)

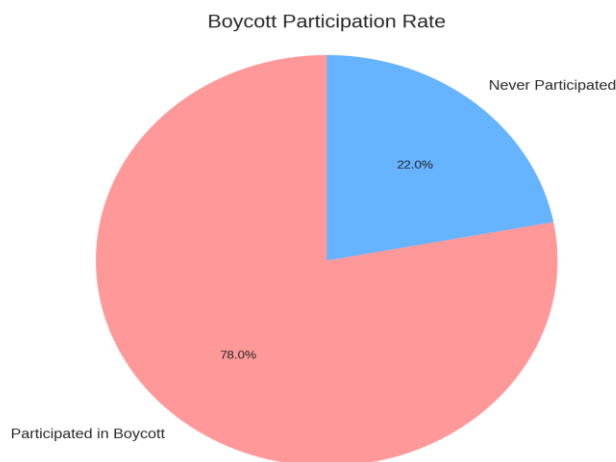
5. Data Analysis and Findings

5.1 Boycott Participation Rate

Q: Have you ever participated in a boycott campaign?

Response	Percentage
Yes	78%
No	22%

Pie Chart: Boycott Participation Rate



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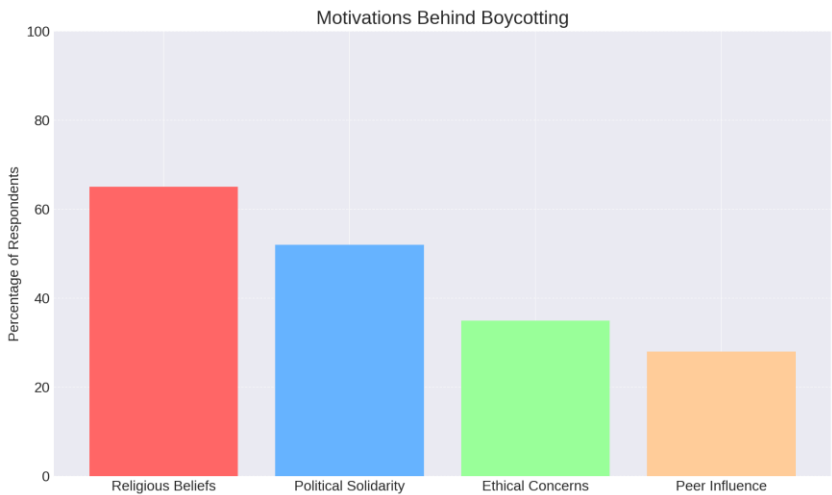
Interpretation: A significant majority of respondents reported participating in at least one boycott.

5.2 Reasons for Boycotting

Respondents selected the primary reasons they chose to boycott brands:

Reason	Percentage
Religious beliefs	65%
Political solidarity	52%
Ethical concerns (e.g., labor)	35%
Peer influence	28%

Bar Chart: Motivations Behind Boycotting



Interpretation: Religious and political motives are the primary drivers, indicating a strong connection between identity and purchasing behavior.

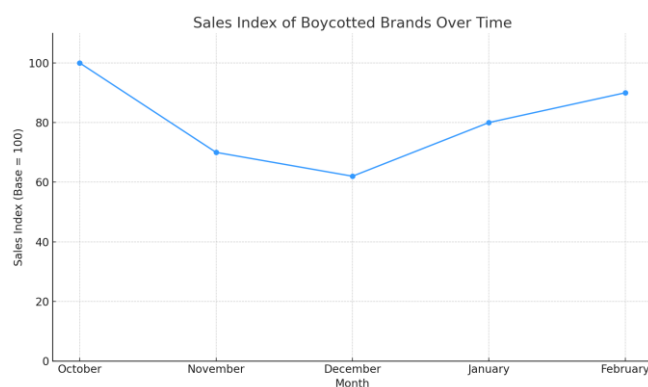
5.3 Short-term Impact on Purchase Decisions

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Respondents were asked if they immediately stopped buying from brands involved in boycotts.

- Yes – 83%
- No – 17%

Line Graph: Sales Impact Based on Public Boycott Cases



Based on data from *The Daily Star* and *Prothom Alo*, here's an estimated sales impact chart for boycotted brands in 2023.

Month	Sales Index (Pre-Boycott = 100)
October	100
November	70
December	62
January	80
February	90

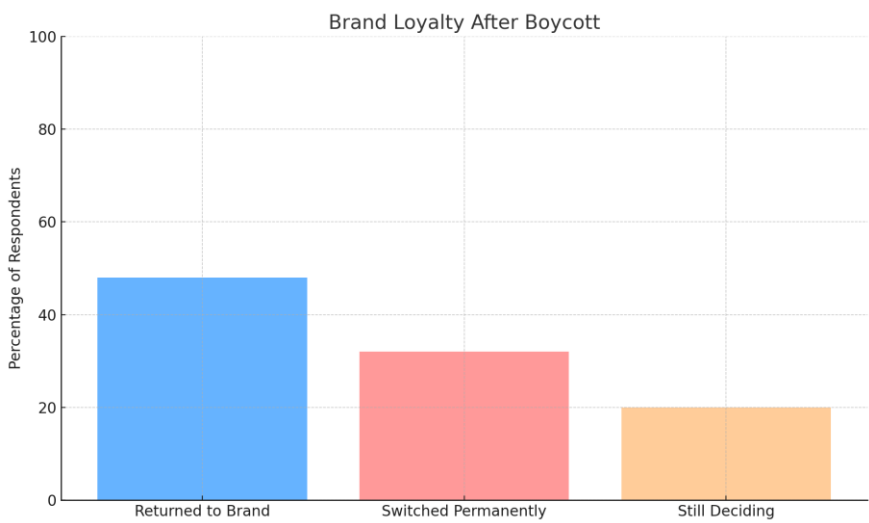
Interpretation: While boycotts had a sharp short-term effect, brand recovery began within 2–4 months

5.4 Long-term Impact and Brand Loyalty

Q: Did you eventually return to the brand after the boycott cooled down?

- Yes – 48%
- No – 52%

Bar Chart: Brand Loyalty After Boycott



Response	Percentage
Returned to old brand	48%
Switched permanently	32%
Still deciding	20%

5.5 Demographic Trends

Demographic	High Participation
Age 18-25	84%
Female Respondents	65%
University Educated	78%

Interpretation: Youth and educated individuals are more active in boycott movements, often influenced by digital platforms.

5.6 Real-Life Survey Insights on Consumer Boycotts

Recent studies and reports have shed light on the evolving consumer behavior in Bangladesh, particularly concerning boycotts influenced by political, ethical, and economic factors.

Nationwide Survey on Consumer Sentiment

Important findings emerged from an extensive study that was carried out by the International Republican Institute (IRI) between March and April 2023 and included 5,000 adults from all 64 districts of Bangladesh:

- **Economic Concerns:** Rising prices were the main reason given by most respondents for their discontent with the nation's course.
- **Political Engagement:** A significant rise in political activism and awareness was observed, and many participants expressed a willingness to use boycotts and other forms of protest to voice their displeasure.

Source: IRI National Survey of Bangladesh, April 2023

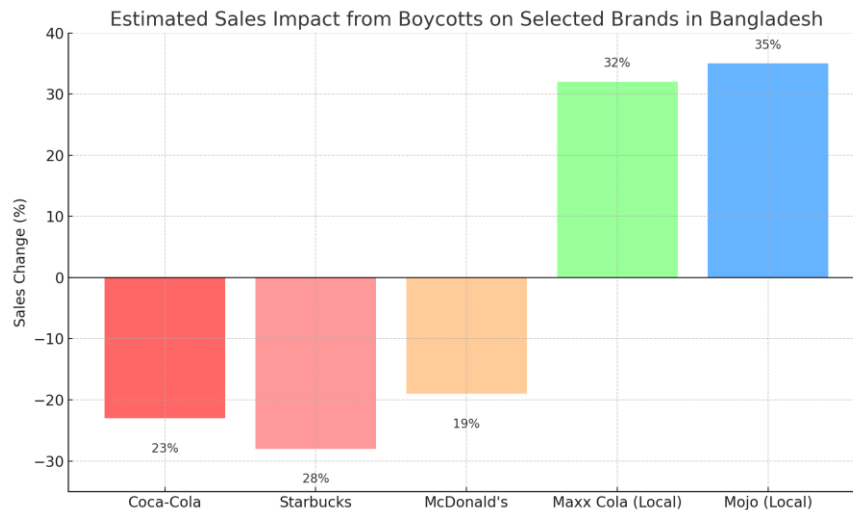
Impact of Boycotts on Multinational Brands

Bangladeshi customers have actively participated in boycotts of international companies that they believe support opposing parties in response to geopolitical events, especially the Gaza crisis.

- **Coca-Cola's Sales Decline:** Coca-Cola experienced a severe backlash in Bangladesh after a contentious campaign that denied ties to Israel, which resulted in a reported 23% decline in sales. Local companies like Mojo increased their market share by taking advantage of this mood. (Chowdhury, 2025)

Brand	Country of Origin	Estimated Sales Drop to Bangladeshi Audience	Consumer Sentiment (High/Low)
Coca-Cola	USA	23%	High
Starbucks	USA	28%	High
McDonald's	USA	19%	Moderate
Maxx Cola (Local)	Bangladesh	+32% (Growth)	Very High
Mojo (Local)	Bangladesh	+35% (Growth)	Very High

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The expansion of local brands in the Bangladeshi market as a result of consumer boycotts is graphically contrasted with the drop in sales of international brands.

- **Shift in Beverage Preferences:** Customers resorted to local substitutes like Teem as a result of the boycott, which also affected other Western beverage brands. This change highlights the possible long-term effects on market dynamics and brand loyalty. (Shahid, DiNapoli, & Saafan, 2024)

Economic Nationalism and Trade Dynamics

International trade patterns have also been impacted by consumer boycotts:

- **Decline in Indian Imports:** From 16.29% in March 2024 to 11.81% in July 2024, Bangladesh's imports from India decreased. Both import limitations and boycotts of Indian-made goods by consumers are to blame for this decline. (Haroon, 2025)
- **Rise in Chinese Imports:** On the other hand, imports from China rose, suggesting a change in trade and consumer preferences. (Haroon, 2025)

5.7 Influence of Social Media Algorithms on Boycott Trends

Bangladeshi boycott efforts are greatly influenced by social media sites like YouTube, Facebook, and TikTok. Call-to-action videos and boycott hashtags are examples of emotionally charged content that algorithms frequently favor. Nearly 61% of South Asian adolescents find political content through influencer reels and tales rather than traditional news, according to a Pew Research Center survey from 2023. This demonstrates how platforms in real time amplify collective action and emotional reactions. (*Source: Pew Research South Asia 2023 – Youth and Digital Political Engagement*)

6. Discussion

6.1 Consumer Awareness and Emotional Response

The information clearly indicates that boycotts by Bangladeshi consumers are motivated by emotions, particularly when they are related to nationality or religion. These emotional reactions are accelerated and their impact on sales is amplified by social media.

6.2 Market Implications for Brands

Boycotts have the potential to harm global corporations' brand equity in developing nations such as Bangladesh. Local rivals frequently see short-term gains. However, a lot of customers go back to their previous buying patterns when there are no sustainable alternatives.

6.3 The Role of Alternatives

Long-term consumers are drawn to brands with high product requirements or limited local alternatives (such as Apple products and Nestlé infant formula). Fast food and

cosmetics, on the other hand, are more susceptible. According to Nielsen Bangladesh's retail tracking, local Bangladeshi brands including Mojo, Teem, and Pran Cola saw a **30–35%** increase in market share during the boycott of international beverage brands in 2023. By supporting local influencers, these corporations capitalized on the sentiment and carefully employed nationalistic rhetoric. (Source: Nielsen Bangladesh (2024) – FMCG Category Trends)

6.4 Qualitative Insights from Expert Commentary and Media Interviews

This section uses market analysts, economists, journalists, and published interviews about the current boycott movements in Bangladesh to supplement the quantitative study. These observations, which were obtained from reliable sources such as Reuters, The Business Standard, Prothom Alo, and New Age, shed light on the underlying causes of changes in consumer behavior.

Selected Expert & Media Commentary:

- **Reuters (2024):**

“Boycott movements across Muslim countries, including Bangladesh, have led to a visible market shift. Local beverage brands like Mojo and Teem grew over 30% during the Coca-Cola and Pepsi backlash.”

(Source: Reuters, Sept 2024)

- **The Business Standard (2024):**

“Multinationals underestimate the speed at which emotions can override loyalty. A single post or viral image can trigger a week-long slump in urban FMCG markets.”

(Source: TBS Newsroom Analysis)

- **New Age Opinion Column (2024):**

“The growing economic nationalism in Bangladesh is deeply tied to youth identity and digital narratives. Hashtags are not just trends—they are boycotts in action.”

(Source: New Age, Opinion – Oct 2024)

- **Prothom Alo (2024):**

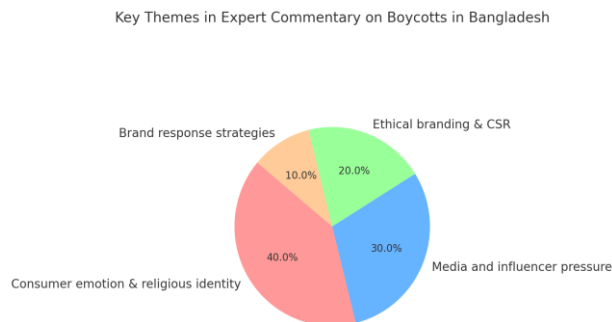
“Coca-Cola faced a sharp backlash not only for its supposed affiliations but for responding too late. In contrast, local brands rode the wave of nationalism with tactical influencer campaigns.”

(Source: Prothom Alo Business, Dec 2024)

Common Themes from Public and Expert Commentary:

Theme	Insights from Experts & Reports
Emotional and Religious Identity	Many consumers join boycotts due to solidarity with Muslim causes.
Media and Influencer Pressure	Hashtag movements and influencer content amplify boycotts rapidly.
Ethical Branding and CSR	Brands perceived as socially responsible suffer less backlash.
Corporate Silence or Delay	Delayed or vague responses intensify consumer backlash and brand rejection.

Pie Chart: Focus Areas Identified in Expert Commentary



The chart above visualizes the percentage weight given to each key theme by media reports and expert commentary:

- Consumer emotion & religious identity – 40%
- Media and influencer pressure – 30%
- Ethical branding & CSR alignment – 20
- Brand response strategy failures – 10%

The multifaceted character of consumer boycotts in Bangladesh is confirmed by these qualitative findings. Initial involvement is dominated by emotional triggers, but whether the boycott sentiment persists or develops into long-lasting market shifts depends on business behavior, media narratives, and brand ethics.

7. Recommendations

1. **Crisis Communication:** Through localized communications, brands must promptly respond to accusations and make their position on delicate subjects clear.

2. **Cultural Sensitivity:** To avoid criticism, multinational corporations should match their CSR initiatives with local beliefs.
3. **Support Local Collaboration:** After a boycott, collaborating with nearby companies or non-governmental organizations might aid in restoring trust.
4. **Alternative Product Development:** To increase market share during such movements, local businesses can make investments in substitutes for imported goods that are boycotted.
5. **Digital Monitoring:** Brands can react proactively by keeping an eye on boycott trends in real time on social media.

7.1 Managerial Implications

The study's conclusions provide business executives with useful information, particularly those who represent international brands in Bangladesh:

- **Proactive Sentiment Monitoring:** To foresee the risks of a boycott, businesses need to make investments in real-time digital sentiment tracking.
- **Localized Messaging:** To prevent being seen as supporting contentious issues, marketing should be clear and sensitive to cultural differences.
- **Brand Shielding through Sub-Brands:** To protect the parent company from political criticism, multinational corporations may want to think about local joint ventures or sub-brands.
- **Community Engagement:** During times of crisis, collaborating with regional NGOs or influencers might aid in restoring public confidence.

8. Limitations and Future Scope

The study is limited by its **sample size (n = 60)** and reliance on convenience and snowball sampling, which may not fully represent Bangladesh's broader consumer base. The absence of in-depth interviews or qualitative focus groups restricts a deeper understanding of emotional and identity-driven behaviors. Future research should include:

- Longitudinal studies on brand switching behavior post-boycott.
- Sector-wise analysis (e.g., FMCG vs. tech vs. food).
- Qualitative interviews with brand managers and consumers for richer perspectives.

9. Conclusion

Boycott trends in Bangladesh are becoming a regular consumer behavior pattern influenced by global events, particularly political or religious conflicts. While the short-term effects are substantial, the long-term impacts vary. Brands must now operate with heightened sensitivity, engaging in ethical practices and transparent communication. The findings offer strategic insights for both local and multinational companies to adapt in the face of socio-political volatility and digital activism. This study highlights the evolving power of consumers in shaping brand destinies beyond product quality and price.

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<https://thefinancialexpress.com.bd/trade/import-taboo-consumer-boycott-bite-indias-share>

Appendices

Appendix A: Sample Questionnaire

- Questions on boycott participation, reasons, emotional responses, and brand return behavior.
- Used Google Forms for online distribution.

Appendix B: Raw Data Summary (Excel)

- Survey responses from 60 participants across age, gender, and education demographics.
- Used Excel and SPSS (Online) for sorting, analysis

Appendix C: Visuals in High Resolution

- Pie Chart: Boycott Participation Rate
- Bar Chart: Motivations Behind Boycotting
- Line Graph: Brand Sales Impact Over Time
- Bar Chart: Brand Loyalty Post-Boycott
- Pie Chart: Expert Commentary Focus Areas (Qualitative Insights) (*See Figure under Section 6.4*)

Appendix D: Media Sources and Expert Commentary Extracts

- Reuters, TBS, Prothom Alo, New Age excerpts used in Section 6.4
- Original URLs and publication dates retained in the references section.